

What is Grammar?

Understanding Grammar

- “rules of a language governing the sounds, words, sentences, and other elements, as well as their combination and interpretation”.

-Britannica

anatomy of a language.

- Practical analysis of a language- its anatomy.
- A system that gives certain rules governing the use of language in general and its constituents elements like phonology, morphology, syntax, semantics, etc. in particular.

-Chomsky

Types of Grammar

- **Prescriptive Grammar**: The "Rules." How people *should* speak (e.g., "Don't end a sentence with a preposition").
- **Descriptive Grammar**: The "Reality." How people *actually* use language to communicate in the real world.
- **Explanatory Grammar**: Why a language is spoken the way it is.
- **Functional Grammar** Studies grammar based on communication function.
- **Historical Grammar** Studies grammar changes over time
- **Comparative Grammar** Compares grammar of different languages.
- **Transformational-Generative Grammar** Explains how infinite sentences can be generated from limited rules.

Features of Prescriptive Grammar

1. Based mainly on written language
Writing is considered standard.
2. Rules are rigid
Breaking rules seen as wrong.
3. Innovations discouraged
New slang or changes often rejected.
4. Teaching Method
General rule first, examples later.

- **Traditional** (theoretical, normative, formal)
- **Written language is considered as the sole basis for the formation of rules**
- Rules- rigid, not to be desecrated
- Any innovation or deviation- considered ungrammatical or “sinful”
- Method of teaching: from general rules to particular instances-
- Inductive or deductive?
- Obstacles? “Changing nature of language”

Features of Descriptive Grammar

1. Function before form
Meaning and communication come first.
2. Natural acquisition
Children learn grammar unconsciously.
They speak correctly before learning rules in school.
3. Used in speech
Language naturally functions in conversation.

- Rules collected from native speakers are encoded, described and used in functional contexts. (Function before form)
- Speaker first uses the language and gradually gains awareness of the rules "unconsciously" as opposed to prescriptive grammar.
- Functions spontaneously in speech.
- Which is that one language which is acquired this way by all of us?

The Building Blocks

1. **Phonology:** The Sound System.
2. **Morphology:** Word Formation.
3. **Syntax:** Sentence Structure.
4. **Semantics:** Literal Meaning.
5. **Pragmatics:** Contextual Meaning.

Phonology

- How sounds/phonemes function in a language
- Phonemic inventory
 - Vowels (Monophthongs, Diphthongs) Monophthongs = single vowel sound (a, e, i)
Diphthongs = gliding vowel sounds (oi, ai)
 - Consonants
- Suprasegmental features: Tone, Intonation, Stress
- Syllable- Syllabic Structure
- Consonant clusters
- Rules of distribution of phonemes

Morphology

- Word formation processes

- Inflection

Changes word form for grammar.

Example:

walk → walked, boy → boys

- Derivation

Creates new words.

happy → unhappy, teach → teacher

- Compounding

Joining two words.

toothbrush, blackboard

- Reduplication

Repeating part or whole word.

bye-bye, tick-tock

- For eg: How is negation done in the language? Where are the adpositions? How is PNG marked in the language? Affixations?

Syntax

Declarative
Interrogative
Imperative
Exclamatory

- What are the sentence types available in the language?
 - Word Order: position of the main constituents inside the clause
 - Complex sentences and Complex Predicates
- Compounding
 - Conjunction, Disjunction, Juxtaposition, Comparison
- Subordination:
 - Relative, Adverbial, Complement clauses, Agreement
 - For eg: Verb to ‘say’ is used as a complementizer in many languages.

Pragmatics

- Domain Analysis

Who speaks what with whom in what context?

- Honorificity, Profanity, Greetings
- Kinship terms and Address terms
- Language Contact, Code Mixing and Switching, Borrowings
- It is not just about being "correct"; but being understood within a social situation- Communicative Competence

Why Does Grammar Matter?

- It prevents "Let's eat Grandma" from becoming a crime scene.
- Knowing the rules allows you to break them with authority
 - It helps in preserving languages and assist in modelling languages for technology.

Common Myths

- *"Grammar is fixed and never changes."*
- *"There is only one 'correct' way to speak."*